

Conclusion

The Politics of Bureaucratic Autonomy

Bureaucrats are politicians, and bureaucracies are organizations of political actors. Autonomy arises when bureaucrats successfully practice a politics of legitimacy. It occurs when agency leaders build reputations for their organizations—reputations for efficacy, for uniqueness of service, for moral protection, and for expertise. It occurs, further, when they ground this reputation in a diverse coalition wrought from the multiple networks in which they are engaged. These coalitions, suspended in beliefs and in networks, and uncontrollable by politicians, are the stuff of autonomous bureaucratic policy innovation. This, I submit, is the basic lesson of the forging of bureaucratic autonomy in the United States. *Bureaucratic autonomy is politically forged.*

Contemporary political science—including an entire literature on bureaucracy that depends on “principal-agent” models of bureaucratic politics—assumes that the linkages between voters and policies occur through parties, elections, representatives, and the legislature. Yet the decisive steps in forging bureaucratic autonomy occurred when federal bureaucrats broke free from the traditional model of politics and established links directly to citizens and the new associations that increasingly claimed their allegiance. Long before the “iron triangles” of the New Deal Era, bureaucracies began to aggregate citizens and voters precisely when parties and politicians were having a difficult time doing so.

Because some agencies did this more successfully than others, the state-building achievement of the Progressive Era was concrete but limited. What emerged in the 1910s and 1920s was not a uniformly more powerful bureaucracy than existed three decades earlier. In pockets of the American state, relative autonomy conditioned upon political legitimacy materialized. Most other agencies lay dormant. Therein lies the puzzle of American state building. Why was the Department of Agriculture able to establish a foothold in writing significant legislation? Why was the Interior Department, with authority over public lands and ties to numerous western interests, unable to capitalize on the movements for conservation and western reclamation? Why were reformers in the Post Office Department able to eliminate systematically the positions of strong Republican identifiers in fourth-class offices at the very time when Republicans enjoyed hegemony in electoral politics? Why were postal officials able to grab all of the moral policing powers they wanted and resist political control of their use? Why was the USDA able to take its newfound authority in

food and drug regulation and turn its fire on the very firms who most supported Republicans during the Progressive period?

The answer lies in the organizational properties of executive agencies at the turn of the century. Bureaucratic autonomy cannot exist apart from the organizational characteristics of the agencies that experience it. If it exists, bureaucratic autonomy *must* be premised not upon the popularity of a policy, not upon occasional administrative fiat, not upon a single well-heeled lobby, but upon the stable political legitimacy of the bureaucracy itself. To focus on organizational reputations is not, as I have emphasized, to divorce bureaucracies from politics. Instead, it is to reconceive politics as a process of coalition building and to acknowledge that in some circumstances bureaucrats can take the decisive initiative (at times, the *only* initiative) in building them. It is to these reputations—and the capacities and coalitions that supported them—that autonomous bureaucracies in America owe their origins.

Is Autonomy the Right Metaphor?

A bureau . . . can coerce the legislators through its powers of propaganda. The procurement of apparent popular support through skillfully conducted publicity may so fortify its position that Congress would hesitate to abolish the bureau or reduce its appropriation.

A group becomes dependent on the existence of the bureau. . . . Moreover, the bureau builds a place for itself in the community and makes demands of Congress in the name of the “public welfare.” New fields of possible usefulness are outlined. Perspicacious, aggressive, well-meaning, the officials, supported by the public benefiting from their services[,] bring forward plans for expansion.

—E. Pendleton Herring, 1934

Can bureaucratic autonomy be a meaningful concept? E. Pendleton Herring discovered half of the answer more than six decades ago. *Autonomy lies not in fiat but in leverage.* Autonomy does not really consist in the ability of bureaus to take clandestine, undetected actions against the wishes of elected authorities. It exists most powerfully when bureaus have acquired lasting esteem and durable links to social, political, and economic organizations, links that rival or surpass those of politicians. For this reason, bureaucratic autonomy arises less in the administration of policy than in its *emergence*. Only a weak autonomy is ob-

served when agencies shirk while administering a law or policy that was of politicians' design. Genuine bureaucratic autonomy exists when agencies take the decisive first moves toward a new policy, establishing an agenda or the most popular alternative that becomes costly for otherwise recalcitrant politicians and organized interests to ignore. It exists when agencies can *alter* the preferences of the public, of organized interests, of presidents, of members of Congress, of media organizations, and of partisan elites. When agencies—by virtue of their recognized legitimacy in a policy area, by virtue of their superior ties to voters or their superior publicity, by virtue of their established reputations for impartiality or pursuit of the national good—can make it politically costly to oppose or restrain their innovations or deny them leeway, they have achieved a form of autonomy that modern political science fails to recognize.¹

It makes little difference for the present account whether these reputations are deserved or well founded. Did the Forest Service protect national forests better than did private landowners? Did the Post Office truly enhance the nation's morals, or did it do the country a profound and lasting disservice by reversing advances in Americans' (especially women's) personal liberty? Did agricultural extension actually improve farm productivity? All of these questions might be answered skeptically. Yet in the early twentieth century, most politically active Americans—citizens active in organizations of all kinds, across geographic sections, across parties, across gender and even class lines—believed that the Post Office and Agriculture Departments offered unique services and protections of lasting value. Not only did Americans view the departments favorably, but they also were clearly enthusiastic about Harvey Wiley, August Machen, Carter Keene, Gifford Pinchot, Anthony Comstock (to a lesser extent, for many civil libertarians), Seaman Knapp, and other officials.

A skeptic might suggest that *innovation* better describes the narratives in this book than autonomy. Clearly not all bureaucratic innovation entails autonomy, but the episodes of policy initiation in this book were, frequently enough, opposed or little sought by presidents, the major parties, congressional committees, and others. Progressive-Era politicians supported bureaucratic innovations only after autonomous agencies made it politically costly to oppose them. Consider then the following episodes of bureaucratic policy reform after 1900:

- the Post Office Department's massive closure of fourth-class offices after 1900 (in which Republicans were not spared);
- the Chemistry Bureau's unyielding prosecution of whiskey firms supported by House Speaker Joseph Cannon;
- the Forest Service's creation and administration of controversial "user fees" when none were contemplated in the 1905 Transfer Act (even by the act's western supporters);
- the Post Office's redirection of postal savings banks from agrarian regions to immigrant-laden areas;

- the USDA's systematic elimination of farmers' institutes—the mode of farm education most favored by the Grange, the NFU, and the states—from the American landscape and their replacement by the Knapp-Spillman county extension system;
- the Post Office's single-handed expansion of arrest powers in the 1890s and its brazen resistance to politicians' attempts to use its inspection authority for partisan ends.

These and numerous other episodes are only weakly described as “innovations.” They were undertaken within the broader energies of Progressive reform, of course, but they were fundamental departures from existing and favored policies. They were first and foremost counter-majoritarian, often initiated against the wishes of the dominant Republican Party (including its Progressive and agrarian wings), and against the dominant institutional actors of the period: congressional committees and their chairs, presidents, and party leaders, except when these actors were subsumed into the agency's coalition. More generally, by shaping the parameters of Progressive legislation itself—by writing laws and amendments that were accepted wholesale by presidents and leaders in Congress—federal bureaucrats in the early 1900s transcended the legacy of clericalism. This often painful break with the past was itself an instantiation of autonomy.²

It merits repeating, however, that Progressive-Era autonomy was not a pan-bureaucratic love affair with the state. If it was, the Interior Department was institutionally forlorn. Nor is it the case that reputations must be universal; not every organization in the early 1900s supported expansions of postal and USDA discretion, and not every group opposed an autonomous Interior Department. The key to strong organizational reputations lay not in their unanimous hold but in their broad social basis.

The Poverty of Procedural Politics

The argument elaborated here poses several challenges to contemporary erudition on bureaucracies. Following the highly influential work of Mathew McCubbins, Roger Noll, and Barry Weingast, a generation of scholars has argued that an agency's “enacting coalition” of politicians can use administrative procedures to induce the agency to take exactly those actions that the coalition desires. These “procedural politics” theories suggest that most of the political action in bureaucratic politics occurs when the methods and processes for a given policy are set by politicians and the interests to which they respond. Hence bureaucratic politics does not really involve bureaucracies at all; “the administrative system is automatic.”

The theory elaborated here suggests that procedural politics is unlikely to control agencies with stable political legitimacy. Agencies with esteemed offi-

cials who have publicly recognized capacity and expertise, and who have independent access to organized citizens, exercise power over the procedures of their agency. Autonomous agencies are powerful bargaining agents in procedural design. The more powerful constraint on administrative procedures is that legitimated agency officials can make it politically costly for politicians to constrain them. Partisans of the procedural-politics school of bureaucracy have discussed all sorts of mechanisms for controlling the bureaucracy without recognizing that these strategies have costs. In some respects, these amount to forfeiting the benefits of agency specialization. The argument here, however, is that when agencies have political legitimacy, the costs of control are *explicitly political and electoral*. William Howard Taft, Joseph Cannon, Eugene Loud, and other Progressive-Era politicians learned this lesson the hard way.

Empirically, procedural accounts are powerless to explain the narratives of this book. Most of the administrative procedures to which political scientists point emerged after the Second World War and the Administrative Procedures Act (APA) of 1946. Indeed, the very passage of the APA came in response to patterns of autonomous action that worried national politicians during a time of bureaucratic expansion. Yet would the narratives of autonomous policy innovation in this book have turned out differently if the Administrative Procedures Act had been in place in 1880? Surely not. Nothing in the APA would have prevented officials in the Post Office and the USDA from developing the experimental programs that they later launched into fully statutory activities of the national government. Beyond this, procedures were then (and are now) powerless to prevent agency coalition building. Nothing in the APA would have prevented Anthony Comstock, Gifford Pinchot, August Machen, Harvey Wiley, and Seaman Knapp, among others, from building reform coalitions of their own making.

The argument here also suggests a counterintuitive criterion for assessing agency independence. In a shrewd argument, McCubbins and colleagues have noted repeatedly over the last two decades that agencies can appear to be taking all of the important actions even when they are fully controlled by their legislative principals. Yet the theory here suggests an appropriate counter to this methodological point. Because autonomous agencies can shift electoral and representative preferences by virtue of their political legitimacy, bureaucracies can be autonomous even when it appears that they are in perfect political alignment with politicians and the public mood. *Political harmony and the appearance of control can mask autonomy.*

The Poverty of Structural Politics

The narratives in this book also reveal difficulties with a related theory of bureaucracy championed by Terry Moe. Moe and other “structural politics” scholars argue that the characteristics of an agency are the product of strategic de-

sign on the part of politicians and all of those interests that are affected by what the agency does. Hence an agency's personnel, its capacities, its turf, and its procedures are subject to a chaotic politics of design that frustrates policymakers' goals. In the politics of procedure, legislators get their way; in the politics of structure, no one does.

Agency structure undoubtedly shapes the potential for bureaucratic autonomy. The stranglehold that clerical organization placed on the Interior Department is an important factor differentiating the political debility of the Interior Department from the autonomy of the USDA. Still, this structure was not the result of systematic design, even by a pluralistic chaos of forces. Clerical organization evolved over five decades as bureaus were lumped onto the department.

The first problem with the structural politics argument is that for the past 150 years, at least, much policy innovation in the United States has occurred within agencies that were created long ago. The bearing of agency design is therefore questionable at best. The narratives here bear out this irrelevance. Stark differences in capacity across the Post Office, Agriculture, and Interior Departments emerged only decades (in the case of the Post Office, a century) after their creation, and ten to twenty years after institutional reforms in the federal civil service and congressional appropriations. Nor was capacity a function of agency size. When Reconstruction ended, the Post Office was the largest government agency; the USDA, by contrast, had a workforce of less than 1 percent of that of the Post Office.

Moreover, agency design in no way predetermined the particular roles that agencies assumed for themselves in forging bureaucratic autonomy. Nothing in the design of the Post Office Department in 1792 (or in the reforms of the early 1860s) intimated the agency's potential as a moral police force, an operator of savings banks, or a rural service machine. Nothing in the design of the U.S. Department of Agriculture in 1862 suggested that the agency would function as a conservation agency, a consumer protection agency, or an education outfit that would take the school to the farm (especially to the southern farm).

The weakness of agency design in shaping Progressive bureaucracy stems in part from the realities of bureaucratic politics. In part, delegation of new laws to agencies more often takes the form of delegation to *existing* agencies than delegation to agencies created *ex nihilo*.³ Yet just as often, new policies come about because agency officials have created the policies in the first place—along with a coalition that favors the policy in the form that bureaucrats created it—and it will therefore be costly for politicians to structure the agency in ways that the agency does not favor. Agencies may not get their way entirely when they innovate, but they will sometimes get their way more than politicians get theirs.

Another problem with design-based theories is that agencies have reasons to depart from the structure they are given. James Q. Wilson has advanced an in-

teresting typology in which agencies are established to be one of four kinds: coping, craft, procedural, and production. Wilson's categories are wonderfully helpful, but they also mislead. The point is not simply that agencies can cross these boundaries but that agencies may have *incentives* to sell themselves as "coping" and "production" agencies (or more) at the same time. Surely no provider of abortion or publisher of erotic literature from 1870 to 1920 would have thought the Post Office a "production agency" alone.⁴

Organizational design also poorly accounts for the emergence (or nonemergence) of capacity—both programmatic and political—in Progressive-Era agencies. The genesis of bureaucratic capacity was primarily an evolutionary outcome. The problem with Moe's argument is that designing constraints is easier than designing capacities. Although Moe is certainly correct when he states that many agencies are "literally designed to fail," it is evident from the history of American bureaucracy that agencies *cannot* automatically be designed to succeed even when politicians want them to. Innovation and planning capacity arose only when long-tenured bureau and division chiefs could draw on the technical and programmatic expertise in their offices. Whereas weak-tie networks were instrumental in bureaucratic recruitment, strong-tie networks within these agencies heightened the attachment of skilled managers and employees. Organizational design was, furthermore, irrelevant to the emergence of these networks. As in many agencies today, collaborative work patterns and information flow were orthogonal to the formal command structure.

The Promise and Failure of State-Building Scholarship

The argument here also speaks to the burgeoning literature in American state building. My principal disagreement is with scholars who ascribe institutional change primarily to "societal" pressures that are embedded in geographic sections, in parties, and in congressional coalitions (Bensel, Sanders, Kernell, and James). I have dealt with some of these arguments in the foregoing chapters. Yet generally, would the sectionalist framework of Bensel and Sanders have forecast these reforms? Would the party-system accounts of James have predicted the occurrence, form, and timing of these changes?

The diverse timing and sequence of these reforms suggest not. A striking feature of the cases of bureaucratic autonomy in this book is their consistent occurrence over a pattern of fifty years—from the Comstock statute of 1873 to the stockyard laws of the early 1920s. These reforms transpired under unified Democratic control of government, under unified Republican control, and under divided government. They happened both when national elections were highly competitive and when one party regularly trounced the other. Most of the innovations—from the Pure Food and Drugs Act of 1906 to the rural free

delivery system—occurred *before* the Cannon Revolt of 1910 and the decentralization of power in Congress. Some important ones—the Postal Savings Act, the Smith-Lever Act, and the parcels post system—occurred afterward.

The emergence of sectionally embedded movements and party constituencies also poorly explains the narratives of innovation here. Many of the policies counted “periphery” agrarians among their coalition partners and intended beneficiaries. Yet many others, including the forest reserve transfer of 1905, the Pure Food and Drugs Act of 1906, the antipornography laws of the 1870s, and the antilottery laws of the 1890s, did not. Moreover, a close historical analysis of two other policies previously thought to be “agrarian”—the twentieth-century farm extension system and the postal savings system—shows that agrarian and populist organizations did not receive their preferred form of policy but rather saw the agency’s own wishes codified into law.

Business-centered accounts also weakly explain bureaucratic policy innovation. Victoria Hattam, Daniel Rodgers, and Kim Voss, in strikingly different narratives, all point to business opposition to state activity as a recurrent force in American political development, and Gabriel Kolko and others gesture to business “capture” of the state as an explanation for Progressive policy. It is remarkable, in this light, how frequently business associations lost out to diverse, bureaucratically centered coalitions in the early twentieth century. In every conceivable respect, business associations suffered defeat in battles over forest conservation and postal savings banks, and in food and drug regulation, parcels post service, and stockyard regulation in the 1920s organized business was beaten in important respects.

Narratives of bureaucratic autonomy have greater concord with “state-centered” theories of institutional change in the United States, notably Skowronek’s *Building a New American State* and Skocpol’s *Protecting Soldiers and Mothers*. These authors rightly identify government officials at the center of institutional change during the Progressive period, and they rightly point to state capacity as a central variable in explaining policy change. Skowronek’s state-building narrative helps to explain the reorientation of Progressive politics around bureaucracy and suggests, appropriately, that arrangements of the “party period” and Gilded Age constrained and enabled the achievements of the Progressive period. Skocpol’s “polity-centered” argument is a powerful addition to Skowronek’s, and it helps point the way to associations between state and society that drive policy reform. In particular, women’s activism—whether in explicitly gender-based federations such as the GFWC or the WCTU or in broader organizations such as moral reform and consumerist leagues—was an important part of the institutional changes detailed here.

At the same time, neither Skowronek’s nor Skocpol’s account accurately and completely points to these changes. Skowronek’s narrative is notable for the *lack* of variation across policy domains in state building. It also has difficulties with instances of bureaucratic autonomy that occurred before 1896, including

Comstockery and the early experience with free delivery. The most promising alternative theory that might explain these reforms is Skocpol's. Yet to conceive of the agency-driven, policy-specific coalitions that emerged in the Progressive period as "polity-based" is a less accurate explanation than a theory that focuses squarely on bureaucratic autonomy and the historically specific conditions under which it emerges.

Whither Presidents?

In separate strains of scholarship, Skowronek, Moe, and James have pointed to presidential action as a crucial force in bureaucratic and regulatory politics. Since all three departments studied here are executive agencies, it warrants asking whether and in what way presidents influenced bureaucratic autonomy. Surely bureaucratic autonomy is more stable when presidents do not actively oppose agency initiatives. Presidential appointment powers are also an important avenue of political control over the bureaucracy. Notwithstanding these powers, agencies that have stable political legitimacy will be able to resist the control strategies of presidents, at least in the short run, as the postal inspection service and Wiley's Bureau of Chemistry were both able to do after 1900. Even a hostile secretary at the helm cannot derail a legitimated agency for long, as the cases of Agriculture Secretary Julius Sterling Morton and Postmaster General Wilson Bissell show. The postal inspection and agricultural extension cases show, moreover, that lower-level program leaders in autonomous bureaucracies who lie beyond the reach of presidential appointment—Anthony Comstock and Seaman Knapp, respectively—can nonetheless shape policy in significant ways.

Autonomy in Time and Space

In this light, the narrative here is not merely a story of autonomy, of "success" for Progressive administrators desiring greater freedom from politicians. The theory laid out in chapter 1 explains the political "dominance" of bureaucracies as much as it accounts for their independence. When agencies in democratic regimes have nothing unique to offer to politicians, and when agencies lack an independent power base, autonomy is not to be expected even if political, economic, and social conditions are highly variable and chaotic. The argument here explains not only why autonomy *did* emerge in the USDA and the Post Office but why it did *not* emerge in these agencies until the *time* that it emerged, and why it did not emerge *at all* in the Department of Interior and many other agencies.

The "panel" character of this study—the narrative analysis of bureaucratic autonomy that varied across agencies *and* over time—offers an important window into the jointly necessary conditions for bureaucratic autonomy. These

dual domains of change ensure that the degrees of historical variation in autonomy exceed the number of explanatory factors I have invoked. As the following points show, the theory here does not overdetermine history from the standpoint of causal inference.

- Before 1900, the USDA had capacity and unique preferences (chapter 6) but *not an embedded reputation*. Not until the USDA's networks were synthesized and its reputation was politically grounded did autonomy emerge.
- The Post Office in the 1890s possessed the social bases of reputation—ties to moral reform leagues, agrarian and business groups—but *lacked demonstrated capacity* in postal operations (chapters 3 and 4). Program autonomy outside of moral policing (where the department had shown considerable capacity as well as network ties) awaited the reduction of the department's operations deficit.
- Any number of agencies in the Progressive period—the Children's Bureau under Julia Lathrop, the Reclamation Service, the Bureau of Corporations—possessed unique preferences but *lacked capacity and the social and reputational bases of legitimacy*.
- A host of other agencies—the Department of Justice, the Department of Treasury, and the ICC—had formal capacities but were *not politically differentiated* from the dominant party coalitions of the Gilded Age and Progressive period.

Organizational Change and the Progressive Achievement

It is useful, in light of this narrative, to rethink what was unique about Progressive politics. Consider the dominant interpretations of Progressivism over the last several decades. Skowronek has narrated American state building as a response to a crisis that, most critically, was mediated by preexisting institutional arrangements. Presidents in particular assume a central role in Skowronek's narrative. Scott James has extended Skowronek's argument to focus on the coalition-building strategies of party leaders, including presidents. Skocpol and Linda Gordon have, from different perspectives, gestured powerfully to the role of gender and women's political organization in Progressive institutional change. In more recent interpretations, Benseel and Sanders have argued that sectional tensions, particularly the antagonism of periphery agrarians, drove numerous Progressive reforms, mediated less through presidents than through Congress. Kolko and Sklar have traced developments from 1890 to 1920 to the interests and ideologies of "conservative" corporate liberalism. Eileen McDonagh and Nicola Beisel, among others, have emphasized the culturally reactionary themes of Progressivism. Samuel Hays and a generation of

succeeding scholars have pointed to the emergence of new movements and organizational forms during the Progressive Era.⁵

The account of Progressive state formation in this book partakes of the riches of these diverse narratives and offers a way of reconciling many of their differences. My intention has been to narrate Progressive reform less as a story of bureaucratically driven change and more as a story of how agency leaders were central actors in coalitions, coalitions hewn from the elements of Progressive political society to whom other historians have given the status of “prime mover” in American political development. The role of reputation in this coalition-building process is crucial. Agency leaders assembled coalitions for their bureaus and their programs not by doling out pork but by building a socially grounded esteem for the activities of their organization. Put differently, congressional leaders, social movements, business groups, presidents, and other actors were all participants in the forging of bureaucratic autonomy in the United States. Yet by pointing to the political centrality of agency leaders, this account offers a clearer view of coalition formation than do other recent studies that focus on coalitions (Sanders and James). Again, the power of bureau officials lay in the *multiplicity* of their ties to political organizations. Multiple networks did not refract power. They rather reduced the dependence of agencies on any one group, putting the agency in the role of broker among numerous interests seeking access to the state.

Congress, the Media, and Multiplicity

In addition, the role of general beliefs about agencies in bureaucratic reputations points to important changes in Congress and the media that enabled agencies to erect reputations. The building of bureaucratic reputations between Congress and executive departments found fertile soil in the Progressive period. Not only were bureau chiefs serving longer tenures, but members of Congress were investing more and more time in committees. As a result, agency officials and their overseers in Congress began to develop a mutual familiarity. The institutional memory of Congress grew, the abilities and interests of bureaus became clearer and more consistent, and uncertainty over the bureaucracy declined. The stability of these relations gave bureau chiefs an incentive to cultivate the trust of committee chairs and congressional party leaders, and some Progressive-Era program leaders adopted this strategy to great advantage.⁶

Perhaps the most important venue of bureaucratic reputation lay in the rapidly expanding media. At a time when broadcast news remained only an imaginary possibility, Americans received their political information from a highly variegated print industry. In this market the critical split was between the larger urban newspapers and related syndicates and the rural farm weeklies. In

the urban newspapers arose the “muckraking” of Progressive reformers, whereas farm editors remained committed to a mix of populist and pro-agrarian sentiments. In part because these papers depended increasingly on the USDA and the Post Office for information and rate classification, both agencies were treated with favor by urban and rural presses. Yet the network advantages of the two agencies transcended mere resource dependence. Numerous Agriculture Department officials were close acquaintances with one or more rural newspaper editors. And newspaper editors, urban and rural, interacted frequently with postal officials over matters of rate classification. As a result of these ties, Progressive-Era citizens were better (and more favorably) informed about the USDA and Post Office than any other agencies in American government.

Reputations for Neutrality and Moral Protection

Traditionally, political scientists have expected greater autonomy where agencies can lay claim to expertise—especially where agencies possess a monopoly on information in a given area. A more interesting case of “policy” in this book emerges from “moral politics” during the culturally conservative Progressive Era. A key component of both the USDA’s and the Post Office’s march to autonomy was their linkages to Victorian moral reformers and their anti-adulteration campaigns, both in the adulteration of food and the adulteration of morals (through pornography and gambling). The Interior Department lacked any such connection to anti-adulteration themes. These moral reputations, and the framing of policy campaigns in terms of “protection” from “the evils of adulteration,” served to enhance the agencies’ esteem for national service. A core component of strong agency reputations is the mien of neutrality, impartiality, or orientation toward the public good. Where an agency’s innovations appear patently to serve its own interests or those of a selected group or region, the political legitimacy necessary for autonomy is less likely to emerge.

In the case of postal state building, coalition building combined moralist Progressives, media organizations, agrarians, and corporate business. Each of these interests sought something different from the Post Office. Progressive Victorians wanted moral policing in the form of Comstockery, agrarians wanted expanded services in rural America and an alternative to institutions dominated by corporate industry, and business interests and the media (for different reasons) wanted an efficient national communications infrastructure. Each saw their interests met in the same programs. Without all four (and more) of these organizational forces, programs such as rural free delivery, parcels post, and postal savings would not have marked Progressive change as they did. More critically, without Anthony Comstock, August Machen, John Wanamaker, and other postal officials to bridge these forces and to create a multifaceted coalition, the possibility of institutional change would have been trifling.

The logic of multifaceted coalitions was demonstrated nowhere more powerfully than in the Department of Agriculture. Republican presidents, women's organizations, conservationists, congressional committees, agrarian organizations—all of these interests converged to influence policy change in areas as diverse as pharmaceutical regulation, forest preservation, and agricultural extension. The central point, again, is that the coalitions were nursed and maintained not by elected politicians but by middle-level bureaucrats. Far more than in Herbert Hoover's Department of Commerce, the "associational state" in America was established in the early-twentieth-century USDA. Unlike Commerce, moreover, the USDA exerted an immense influence on the groups in its coalitions.

The unprecedented multiplicity and diversity of civic and voluntary associations during the period 1880–1920 enabled bureaucratic officials to enter and occupy these unique positions. As Theda Skocpol, Marshall Ganz, and Ziad Munson have recently argued, the period from the Civil War to the New Deal was a high point of organizing activity in the United States. Gerald Gamm and Robert Putnam have emphasized the local character of these associations, and Skocpol and her colleagues have echoed Elizabeth Clemens and emphasized their federated and institutionalized character. These organizations permeated numerous sectors of American life. Martin Sklar, Gabriel Kolko, and Daniel Rodgers have, in different ways, documented the rise of corporate political activity during the Progressive period. Other scholars have drawn attention to unprecedented organizing activity in rural America, pointing to the Grange, the Farmers' Alliance, and thousands upon thousands of local groups and farm cooperatives. Skocpol and other scholars have pointed to new energies on the part of women's groups, and Paul Boyer and Nicola Beisel have focused on moral reform organizations. Bureaucratic autonomy, in this view, is enabled not so much when economic tension arises among tightly defined classes—as in Skocpol's *States and Social Revolutions* or Skowronek's *Building a New American State*—but precisely when cross-cutting networks allow state officials to achieve multiple embedments in a complex society. These embedments create the possibility for coalition building from diverse elements, and they enhance the agency's appearance of neutrality. When agencies' favored innovations drew support from agrarians, business organizations, women's groups, and moral reform associations, it became much harder for politicians to resist them or to stall.⁷

The organizational flourishing that was characteristic of Progressive society offers one reason that the patterns of bureaucratic autonomy witnessed in this book are less likely to be observed in contemporary politics. To be sure, modern America is rife with organizations in the formal sense. Yet if Putnam, Skocpol, and other analysts of American society are correct, the day-by-day embedment of Americans in organizations has waned, not strengthened, over the last few decades. The challenge of contemporary American state building,

in this view, may demand more than “reinventing” American government—although as Paul Light has argued in *Thickening Hierarchy*, it may demand a reduction in the “layers” of political appointments that separate the most talented career officials from status-laden discretionary positions. Future state building may depend as much on societal change as on governmental reform.⁸

Contemporary Examples, Future Possibilities

Although contemporary American politics has reduced the likelihood of bureaucratic autonomy founded on legitimacy, at least one case in recent years accords more or less with the theory presented here. The Food and Drug Administration (FDA)—no longer a child bureau of the USDA but an agency under the Department of Health and Human Services—is a highly legitimized actor in contemporary American politics. Although its detractors have been growing in recent years, the FDA has held tremendous power over the pharmaceutical industry since the Food, Drug and Cosmetic Act of 1938 and the Kefauver-Harris Amendments of 1962. The reputational bases of these policy reforms are striking. Both occurred after the FDA had acted to stem vast consumer crises in adulterated medicines, first in the sulfanilamide scandal of 1937, then in the thalidomide tragedy of 1960–61. In both cases, and especially in the second, the FDA received public credit for protecting the American public from the hazards of consumer goods. Moreover, the agency has long profited from its placement at the crossroads of a diverse set of interests—pharmaceutical companies, consumer safety advocates, the American medical profession, farmers and organic food growers, academic scientists, and other groups. In recent years the FDA has maintained its unique presence in American politics, successfully pressing for expansions of its budget in the Prescription Drug User Fee Act of 1992 and radically (though as yet unsuccessfully) proposing authority over tobacco products in the last decade.

From the Civil War to the Great Depression, in pockets of the American state, genuine bureaucratic autonomy was forged on the anvil of agency reputations. The primary actors in this saga were bureau chiefs and program leaders driven by maximal control over their programs and organizations. These leaders took direction of the hiring process in the Gilded Age, using weak-tie networks and internal socialization to transform their agencies into politically distinct entities. They built capacity by assembling talented offices where turnover was minimized, and they used inspection and other intermediary institutions to reintegrate their organizations. They completed the process by participating in the construction of lasting legitimacy in the form of organizational reputations, forms of institutional trust that were embedded in elite and local networks. In bureaucratic entrepreneurship the policy fruits of this process came to shape decisively the parameters of the American state.

The patterns of bureaucratic policy innovation observed in this narrative may or may not be praiseworthy. Autonomous policymaking does not necessarily translate into successful policy. Yet the autonomy narrated here is one in which bureaucratic power grew not at the expense of democratic participation but in a symbiotic relationship with it. Precisely because federal agencies shrewdly orchestrated the participatory energies of American politics, they cleared a unique policymaking place for themselves in the American institutional order, at least for a time. If the stories of statehood in this book offer promise, the challenge of American state building may be to reengage state bureaucracies with the very civic organizations and social networks in which they once flourished.

